of it. In the following days, *Kerala Kaumudi* came out with an 'exclusive' linking I G Raman Srivastava with the spy ring. In his book *Spies from Space: The ISRO Frame-up*, Rajasekharan Nair explains the Malayalam daily's motive in fixing Srivastava who evicted its editor M S Mani from the office, following a court order on a family feud. This came as a shot in the arm for the 'Oommen Chandy-led Antony' faction of the Congress to hit at Chief Minister K Karunakaran. The faction constituted a crack team that kept feeding Malayalam journalists' imaginary tales of the spy case. Srivastava was suspended later, following adverse remarks by the Kerala High Court (which was later chided by the Supreme Court), and Karunakaran lost his chair. Those were two victories for two minor players who were not aware of the bigger conspiracy, which was being hatched by some foreign hands to delay, if not prevent, India from entering the commercial satellite launch market.

With Vijayan finding the names of ISRO scientist Sasikumaran in Mariam's diary, the stage was set to link the arrested women with the space organisation. As the newspapers went to town with the spy women's links with ISRO scientist Sasikumaran, ISRO made the wrong move of transferring him to Satellites Application Centre (SAC), Ahmedabad on 5 November 1994.

Behind this move was Sengupta, an IAS officer in the space department with whom Sasikumaran had a tiff earlier. In a review meeting, the bureaucrat had chided Sasikumaran, saying he did not understand administration. Sasikumaran, for his part, retorted that he as an IAS man did not understand technology. Now, with his name linked to Mariam Rasheeda, Sengupta made haste to impress upon the ISRO chairman to sign on the dotted line to transfer Sasikumaran.

On 9 November 1994 the day Sasikumaran joined SAC, Ahmedabad, Fauziyya Hassan was arrested in Bangalore and brought to Trivandrum. The next day, IB joint director M K Dhar came to Trivandrum, marking a turning point in the case. It was on this day that the IB claimed to have got the first 'confession statement' from Fauziyya about espionage. On 13 November 1994, Mariam and Fauziyya were charged with espionage.